

The Perfect Wedding

Routine discussions about the family's finances are a good way to avoid periodic surprises and to keep each other informed. Although talking about money may be uncomfortable at first, it will become a habit over time. You may also discover that your money arguments will decrease. The more situations that can be resolved before they become major problems, the better. Unfortunately, Jennifer did not see the value of disclosing her financial decisions to her fiancé.

Jennifer started planning her wedding to Cliff as soon as he proposed during his senior and her junior year at Northwestern University. She wanted the wedding to be perfect and wouldn't settle for anything less; it didn't matter how much it cost. She wanted to hire the most expensive band, the best caterer, the most elegant reception hall, a designer wedding dress, and a honeymoon at a five-star resort.

Their parents contributed financially to the wedding, but not on the scale that Jennifer envisioned. Cliff thought Jennifer was being a little extravagant, but he wasn't really aware of the expense since Jennifer was handling all the arrangements. Besides, he didn't want to upset his fiancée, whom he loved deeply, by appearing to be stingy.

The wedding was perfect, just as Jennifer had planned. When they settled back into their apartment after their honeymoon, a stack of mail awaited them. Jennifer was exhausted and went to bed. Cliff stayed up and opened their mail. To his astonishment, the majority of their mail was wedding bills. In fact, after he added up all the bills, the grand total was \$50,000!

Jennifer had asked for many of the wedding expenses to be billed to them and put the others on her many credit cards. Cliff was furious, he couldn't believe she could have spent so much money without his approval. They had planned to buy a

